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RAMADAN UPDATES

Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

RESIDENTS END FAST AT MASS IFTAR

■ Residents end their fast at a mass iftar organised by DAMAC Alkhair at Al Salam Mosque in Al Barsha yesterday. This Ramadan, a citywide home decoration competition is now open for entries, with a top prize of Dh100,000 up for grabs and a total of 15 winners set to be rewarded for bringing the spirit of the fasting month to life on their doorsteps. SEE ALSO P4, 8-9, 15

UAE moves to end medicine monopoly

BETTER DRUG SUPPLY, NO SHORTAGES AND FAIR COMPETITION ENSURED

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

In a first-of-its-kind move, the UAE yesterday implemented a new rule to break the monopoly on medical products.

The Emirates Drug Establishment (EDE) activated the new mechanism that requires pharmaceutical companies to appoint more than one authorised agent for each medical product marketed in the country.

That means medicines will be easier to find and less likely to run short in the UAE.

According to the EDE, the decision aligns with the UAE's strategic priorities to strengthen national readiness, enhance pharmaceutical security and ensure the sustainable availability of medical products across the country. "It also seeks to promote the attractiveness of the business environment for investment, reinforcing the UAE's global competitiveness and expanding treatment options available for the same condition," the EDE said.

Faster responses

The new mechanism aims to end the monopoly on medical products and mitigate the risk of supply disruptions resulting from emergencies or operational challenges.

In addition, the mechanism will enhance supply chain flexibility by enabling faster responses to fluctuations in demand and public health emergencies, improving distribution efficiency through better inventory management, and accelerating the delivery of medical products across all emirates.

The new rule requires pharmaceutical companies to appoint more than one authorised agent for every product they market in the country.

Furthermore, the initiative will contribute to diversifying distribution channels, preventing monopolistic practices related to quantity control or supply timing, boosting competitiveness among pharmaceutical establishments, encouraging fair competition in logistics services, and raising standards for quality, storage and transportation.

Saeed Bin Mubarak Al Hajeri, Minister of State and Chairman of the Board of Directors of the EDE, said "EDE is committed to strengthening the diversification of supply chains, enhancing regulatory efficiency, and establishing a flexible legislative environment that supports the sustainability of the pharmaceutical market and the protection of public health."

PRAYER TIMINGS

IFTAR 18:22

Fajr	05:28	Shuruq	06:42
Dhuhur	12:35	Asr	15:52
Maghrib	18:22	Isha	19:36

IMSAK 05:18
Add 4 minutes for Abu Dhabi, deduct 4 minutes for RAK and 6 minutes for Fujairah

MIDDLE EAST
US military build-up near Iran signals multi-week air campaign | P7

Etihad to hire 3,000 staff per year

Airline posts highest profit of Dh2.6b capping 4th straight year of profitability

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

8.4%
Etihad's profit margin, more than double the industry average

UAE's national airline Etihad Airways plans to continue large-scale recruitment as it expands its fleet, with the airline expecting to hire between 2,500 and 3,000 people per year over the next five years.

The guidance follows a year of significant hiring in 2025, when the Abu Dhabi carrier recruited more than 3,200 new employees and promoted around 2,200 staff across the organisation, it said yesterday.

Airline CEO Antonoaldo Neves said the airline expects to maintain a similar pace of recruitment going forward.

"We're going to keep that range, from 2,500 to 3,000 hires per year, and we're going to keep about 20 aircraft per year, so that's more or less the ratio that we're going to be doing for the next five years," he explained.

The airline also reported its strongest full-year financial and operational performance on record, marking its fourth consecutive year of profitability.

The strong operating performance and unit cost discipline resulted in a profit after tax of Dh2.6 billion, up 47 per cent year-on-year, with profit margin improving to 8.4 per cent (+1.5pp year-on-year). This is equivalent to more than double the average net profit margin of 3.9 per cent, according to IATA's December 2025 estimates.

SEE ALSO P-II